



## FOOD FOR THOUGHT

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# Hunger games

The food choices made during puberty can **shape** an athlete's growth, recovery and performance for years to come.

I have spent more than two decades watching young bodies turn into athletic ones. If there is one stage where I see the most mistakes being made, it is during puberty.

This is the window when everything is being built, and also when a growing, hungry teenager is most likely to be put on the wrong diet.

Let me start with the part most parents and coaches get backwards. The biggest danger for a young athlete during these years is not eating too much. It is eating too little.

Puberty is the fastest your child will ever grow after their first year of life, and you are asking that same body to train, recover and compete at the same time. When food does not match demand, the body quietly starts cutting corners. Growth slows. Recovery suffers.

In girls, periods can become irregular or stop altogether, which is a loud warning sign that the tank is running on empty. I have seen talented 13- and 14-year-olds who were tired all the time. Many of them skipped breakfast and trained on an empty stomach. The answer was

almost never their training programme. It was their fork.

So the first rule in my book is simple: feed the growth first, then the sport. A teenage athlete needs more food than an adult, not less.

This is where the diet often goes wrong. Carbohydrates have become the villain in too many homes because adults are reading about low-carb diets designed for desk jobs and middle age. A growing athlete is neither. Rice, roti, poha, idli, fruit and even a little sweet after a hard session are fuel, not guilt. Cut the carbs from a young player and you cut their energy, their mood and their ability to last the second half.

The two nutrients I worry about most are iron and calcium. In our part of the world, many young athletes eat little or no meat, which makes iron a real concern, especially for girls who are now losing blood every month.

Low iron shows up as breathlessness, poor concentration in class and a heavy-legged feeling in the last 20 minutes of a match. Pair dal with something rich in Vitamin C, green leafy vegetables, jaggery and eggs if the family eats them, and get

levels checked rather than guessed.

If the household is fully vegetarian, Vitamin B12 deserves attention too. It sits quietly behind both energy and a clear head, and a simple blood test once a year will tell you where you stand.

Calcium and the bone story is the one I beg families not to ignore. Nearly all of the bone strength a person will carry through life is laid down by the late teens. Miss that window and you cannot make it up later. This is the time for curd, milk, paneer, ragi and sesame to become daily habits rather than occasional ones. Strong bones today can be the difference between a long career and a stress fracture at 22.

About protein, I want to calm everybody down. Yes, it matters for building muscle and repairing it after training. No, your 15-year-old does not need a tub of protein powder. The dal, curd, eggs, paneer, chicken or fish already cooked in most kitchens, spread across the day, will do the job beautifully. A glass of milk and a couple of eggs often do more honest work than most supplements on the shelf.

This brings me to my favourite